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History 97

The Memory of the Civil War in American Culture

The Civil War

(1861-1865)

The Civil War marked one of the great defining moments in United States history. Long simmering sectional tensions reached a critical stage in 1860-61 when eleven slaveholding states seceded and formed the Confederate States of America. Political disagreement gave way to war in April 1861, as Confederates insisted on their right to leave the Union and the loyal states refused to allow them to go. Nothing in the nation's history had prepared Americans for the scale of military fury and social disruption that ensued. Four years of fighting claimed more than a million military casualties (of whom at least 620,000 died), directly affected the lives of hundreds of thousands of civilians, and freed four million enslaved African Americans. The social and economic system based on chattel slavery that the seceding states had sought to protect lay in ruins. The inviolability of the Union had been confirmed, as had the supremacy of the national government over the individual states. In the longer term, preservation of the Union made possible the American economic and political colossus that figured so prominently in 20th century history.

Also known as "The War of the Rebellion," "The War Between the States," "The War for Southern Independence," and "The Brother's War," the conflict continues to fascinate professional historians, novelists, filmmakers, and millions of Americans interested in history. The drama and tragedy of many Civil War battles have been commemorated in a number of national military parks, such as the ones at Gettysburg, Pennsylvania, Antietam, Maryland, and Vicksburg, Mississippi. Many of the major issues of the era--slavery, state rights, racial equality, the duties and rights of citizenship, and the limits of national authority--continue to provoke debate and dissention.

Before the sectional disruption, the American republic had survived diplomatic and military crises and internal stresses. It weathered tensions with France in the late-1790s, a second war with Britain in 1812-1815, and disputes regarding international boundaries. Political disputes over economic issues such as the tariff, a national bank, and government supported public works proved divisive but posed no serious threat to the integrity of the Union. Despite fissures along ethnic and class lines, the majority of Americans had much in common. They were white, Christian, spoke English, and celebrated a shared heritage forged in the crucible of the Revolutionary War.

Questions relating to the institution of slavery provoked the sectional strife that eventually erupted in war. Most men and women at the time would have agreed with Abraham Lincoln's assertion in his second inaugural address that slavery "was, somehow, the cause of the war." Earlier, Alexander H. Stephens, the Confederacy's vice president, had proclaimed that slavery "was the

immediate cause of the late rupture and the present revolution" to establish southern independence. The framers of the United States Constitution had compromised regarding slavery, creating a democratic republic that sought to ensure its citizenry's freedoms while also reassuring the South that individual states would have the power to maintain and regulate slavery within their boundaries. The paradox of white liberty that rested in part on a foundation of black slavery was thus imbedded in the origins of the United States.

Debates over slavery's expansion into federal territories, which were tied to the South's effort to maintain an equal number of free and slave states, created turmoil in national politics. The Missouri Compromise of 1820, the Wilmot Proviso of 1846 (which sought to prohibit slavery in lands acquired as a result of the Mexican-American War), the establishment of the Free Soil movement in 1848, the Compromise of 1850 (which ended parity in the Senate with California's admission as a free state), the Kansas-Nebraska Act of 1854 (which helped foster deadly territorial violence), and the Supreme Court's Dred Scott decision in 1857 marked mileposts along the road to sectional disruption. Outside the arena of national politics, the rise of the abolition movement, Nat Turner's bloody slave revolt in Virginia in 1831, publication of Harriet Beecher Stowe's antislavery bestseller *Uncle Tom's Cabin* in 1852, and John Brown's raid on Harpers Ferry in 1859 fed fears in the South that their slave-based social and economic systems might be in jeopardy.

As sectional divisions deepened, important institutions failed to act as stabilizing forces. Several Protestant denominations, including the Baptists and

Methodists, split into northern and southern branches. The national political parties, which from the 1830s until the early 1850s had pursued compromise to maintain northern and southern wings, fractured along regional lines. The Whig Party collapsed as a national entity after the presidential election of 1852, and many northern voters came to view the Democratic Party as pro-southern. The Republican Party, which rapidly gained strength in the North following its creation in the mid-1850s, adamantly opposed extension of slavery into the territories and won virtually no support in the South. The Supreme Court, long venerated by citizens across the nation, lost its reputation as an impartial arbiter of legal questions when the Dred Scott decision seemed to open all federal territories--and perhaps free states as well--to slavery.

Historians have debated whether the North and South had become markedly different societies by 1860. Some portray the free-soil North, with its burgeoning commercial and industrial interests, as an emerging capitalist giant at odds with an overwhelmingly agrarian South where most capital was invested in land and slaves. Others insist that the North and South were far more alike than different. It is clear that by the late-1850s many Americans believed there were fundamental differences between the sections. More ominously, a significant number on each side of the Mason-Dixon Line had come to distrust those on the other side who disagreed with them about how slavery should figure in the republic's future.

The election of 1860 triggered the secession crisis. Although Lincoln and the victorious Republicans had promised not to interfere with slavery in states

where it already existed, they firmly opposed slavery's spread to any federal territories. Between December 1860 and February 1861, the seven Deep South states seceded to avoid what they perceived as a long-term threat to their slaveholding interests. After Confederates fired on Fort Sumter in mid-April 1861, Lincoln's call for 75,000 volunteers to suppress the rebellion prompted four slave states of the Upper South, including Virginia, to join their Deep South brethren. Four other slave states, typically called the Border States, remained loyal to the Union.

Both sides mobilized on a scale unprecedented in American history. Drawing on an 1860 population of just more than 1,000,000 military-age white males, the Confederacy placed between 800,000 and 900,000 men in uniform (fragmentary records do not permit a precise count). The North mustered at least 2.1 million men, about half of its 1860 military-age population. More than 180,000 black men served in United States units. Apart from its much larger population, the North held a decided advantage in industrial capacity. In 1860, there were 110,000 northern manufacturing establishments employing 1,300,000 workers; in the Confederate states, just 18,000 establishments employing 110,000 workers.

Yet either side could have prevailed because of the North's more daunting requirements for victory. The Confederacy sought independence and only had to defend itself to prevail. The North sought to compel the seceded states to abandon their hopes to found a new nation. United States armies would have to invade the Confederacy, destroy its capacity to wage war, and crush the will of

the southern people to resist. The Confederacy could win by prolonging the war to a point where the northern people considered the effort too costly in lives and money. Many Confederates appreciated the magnitude of the North's challenge. George Wythe Randolph, who served as Confederate secretary of war, commented in 1861 that Union forces "may overrun our frontier States and plunder our coast but, as for conquering us, the thing is an impossibility."

Union and Confederate leaders adopted very different strategies to achieve victory. Beginning in 1861 with Winfield Scott's so-called "Anaconda Plan," the United States pursued a strategy that included a naval blockade to restrict the flow of goods into southern ports, a combined army-navy effort to divide the Confederacy by seizing control of the Mississippi River, and major offensives into the Confederate hinterlands. The Confederacy first tried to defend all of its borders, but the futility of such a strategy soon became apparent. For most of the war, Jefferson Davis and his advisers followed what often is termed a defensive-offensive strategy. Confederate armies generally stood on the strategic defensive, protecting as much of their territory as possible. When circumstances seemed favorable, the Confederacy launched offensives--the most important of which culminated in the battles of Antietam and Perryville in 1862 and Gettysburg in 1863.

Military fortunes ebbed and flowed for more than three years before United States forces gained a decisive advantage. The North wavered more than once in its determination, most notably after Robert E. Lee frustrated Union offensives in the spring of 1863 and the spring and early summer of 1864. A string of Union

successes in the West--won by Ulysses S. Grant at Forts Henry and Donelson, Shiloh, Vicksburg, and Chattanooga in 1862-63 and by William Tecumseh Sherman at Atlanta in 1864--more than counterbalanced Lee's successes. By the autumn of 1864, with Grant as the Union general-in-chief, United States armies applied pressure in Virginia, Tennessee, and the Carolinas that eventually forced a Confederate surrender in the spring of 1865.

Both sides made use of recent technological advances. Railroads moved hundreds of thousands of soldiers and vast quantities of supplies, and telegraphic communication permitted both governments to coordinate military movements in widely separated areas. The conflict featured numerous applications of recent military technology, among the most important of which were the rifle musket carried by most infantrymen on both sides and ironclad warships that saw action on a broad scale.

The war touched the lives of almost every American. Women assumed larger responsibilities in the workplace. In the North, they labored as nurses (previously a male occupation), government clerks, factory workers, and in other ways helped the war effort. Southern white women also worked as clerks and nurses and in factories, and thousands took responsibility for running farms. Several hundred women disguised themselves as men and served in the military. Although the war opened opportunities outside the household for women, its end brought a general return of old patterns of employment.

Slaves in the South shouldered a major part of the labor burden--as they always had--and made it possible for the Confederacy to put nearly 80 per cent

of its military-age white men in uniform. No group was more directly affected by the outcome of the war than the four million black people who were slaves in 1861. They emerged from the struggle with their freedom (made final by ratification of the 13th Amendment to the Constitution in December 1865), though the extent to which they would be accorded equal rights remained unresolved.

The two national governments expanded their powers in an effort to mount sustained war efforts. Ironically, the Confederacy, a republic allegedly devoted to state rights, witnessed greater governmental intrusions into its citizens' lives. Both sides enacted a series of national taxes, tampered with civil liberties in various ways, and resorted to conscription laws. Many of these measures, especially the drafts implemented by the South in 1862 and by the North the following year, provoked heated political debate and overt antiwar activities. The war produced spending on a scale dwarfing that of any earlier period. In 1860, the federal budget was \$63,000,000; in 1865, United States expenditures totaled nearly \$1.3 billion--a 200-fold increase that does not include the roughly \$1 billion the Confederate government spent.

Emancipation marked the war's most revolutionary development. Abolitionists and many Radical Republicans pressed for it from the outset, but the mass of white northerners considered the conflict a struggle for Union rather than for black freedom. As fighting dragged on and casualties mounted, Lincoln presented emancipation as a tool that would undermine the Confederacy. Although many Democrats remained bitter opponents, most white northerners eventually accepted emancipation as necessary to victory. Hundreds of

thousands of slaves in the South did not wait for United States politicians to work out their fate, fleeing to Union military lines and thereby applying pressure for governmental action that would transform a struggle for Union into a struggle for Union and freedom.

The cost of the war was appalling. More Americans were killed than in all other wars combined from the colonial period through the last phase of the Vietnam War. Had American deaths in World War II been proportionately as high, the total would have been 2.6 million rather than the 405,000 actually lost. The war brought wide-scale economic destruction to the Confederate states, which lost two-thirds of their assessed wealth (emancipated slaves accounted for much of this). In contrast, the northern economy thrived. Two numbers convey a sense of the relative economic cost: between 1860 and 1870, northern wealth increased by 50 per cent; during that same decade, southern wealth decreased by 60 per cent.

Human suffering extended beyond the military sphere and continued long after fighting ceased. During the conflict, scores of thousands of black and white southerners became refugees (far fewer northern civilians experienced the war so directly). An unknown number of civilians perished at the hands of guerrillas, deserters, and, less frequently, regular soldiers in both armies. After the war, thousands of veterans struggled to cope with lost limbs and other physical and emotional scars. Thousands of families faced difficult financial circumstances due to the loss of husbands and fathers. The United States government made

available minimal support for widows of soldiers, and southern states did the same for widows of Confederates.

The Civil War was the central event in the lives of most of the soldiers who served. During the postwar years, many joined veterans' organizations such as the Grand Army of the Republic and the United Confederate Veterans. They revisited the sites of their battles, raised monuments to commemorate their service, and, in significant numbers, wrote reminiscences. For black Union soldiers, the war provided the strongest possible claim for full citizenship. They had risked their lives alongside white comrades, and they justly claimed the right to vote and otherwise live as full members of American society.

Americans remembered the war in different ways. For most white northerners, it was preeminently a crusade that saved the Union. Black Americans placed freedom at the center of their memories of the conflict. Many ex-Confederates celebrated their failed effort to carve out a distinct destiny. Their arguments, which included an attempt to minimize the importance of slavery as a factor during the secession crisis and the war, became part of the remarkably durable "Lost Cause" school of interpretation. By the end of the 19th century, a reconciliationist movement united many white northerners and southerners in a shared public memory of the war. Reconciliationists rarely spoke of emancipation or black participation and deliberately avoided discussion of the bitter animosities that had divided North and South. They applauded the pluck of white soldiers North and South, often glossed over the question of which side was right, and presented the war as a grand demonstration of American valor

and virtue. The reconciliationist vision, with its emphasis on shared courage and its aversion to acrimonious topics, continues to wield a powerful influence on the popular understanding of the Civil War.

Source: Joan Waugh, editor, Civil War and Reconstruction, 1856 to 1869. (New York: Facts on File, 2003; 2nd ed., 2009). Volume 5, of Gary B. Nash, general editor, Encyclopedia of U.S. History